

CASE STUDY

MyDesignation

How a Husband-Wife Duo from Trivandrum Built a

Rs 100 Crore Fashion Brand on Community and Culture

Prepared for aspirational founders building from Tier 2/3 India

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The Snapshot

Before we get into the story, here are the numbers that matter.

Metric	Detail
Founders	Swaroop Krishnan (CEO) and Gopika B Raj (CCO)
Founded	2017 (Pvt Ltd registered 2020)
Headquarters	Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala
Revenue Growth	100% year-on-year for 4 consecutive years
FY25 Revenue	Rs 16 crore (Rs 60 crore ARR, targeting Rs 100 crore)
Profitability	Profitable since early years. Bootstrapped for 5 years before raising.
Total Funding	\$5.66 million (~Rs 50 crore) across 2 rounds
Lead Investor	RPSG Capital Ventures (also behind Souled Store, mCaffeine, Perfora)
Customers Served	~10 lakh (1 million)
Instagram Followers	6.2 lakh+
Return Rate	Below 5% (industry average: 25-40%)
Repeat Purchase Rate	30-35% monthly
D2C Revenue Share	90% of revenue from own website. Minimal marketplace reliance.
Stores	5 exclusive outlets (Bangalore, Kochi, Trivandrum, Calicut, Lulu Mall)
Store Break-even	Within 3-4 months of opening
Team Size	~100 employees

The Founders

Swaroop Krishnan and Gopika B Raj are a husband-and-wife team from Thiruvananthapuram. They met during school at Chinmaya Vidyalaya in Trivandrum, where they bonded over a shared obsession with expressive, colourful clothing.

Gopika had a natural instinct for design. She would create her own outfits, and Swaroop would source the materials. When she started posting her designs on social media, friends and family began placing orders. That was the first signal.

Both were academically strong. Gopika graduated in Civil Engineering from Mar Baselios College. Swaroop earned his degree from Vellore Institute of Technology. Both topped their colleges. Both sat out of campus placements entirely. They had already decided to build something of their own.

The Origin Story

The Flea Market Moment

In January 2017, Swaroop and Gopika formally launched MyDesignation. In their first month, they generated around Rs 1 lakh in revenue from Trivandrum customers.

The real breakthrough came at a local flea market called Olam in Trivandrum. They scraped together enough money to print 300 T-shirts featuring iconic Trivandrum landmarks and catchy Malayalam phrases. They had three days to sell.

Every single piece sold out within 3 hours. On top of that, 800 pre-orders were placed on the spot.

This was proof of concept. People wanted fashion that reflected their identity and culture, not generic mass-produced apparel. The founders did not build a massive operation based on assumptions. They tested with minimal capital and let customer response decide the next step.

Building the Brand Identity

From that point, MyDesignation positioned itself as a design-led, community-driven brand. Instead of chasing fast-fashion trends, they drew from traditional South Indian art forms: Kathakali, Theyyam, mythical characters, regional language, and local landmarks. Every collection was built around a defined creative concept.

One of their signature products is the Raven Embroidered shirt, which requires over 300,000 stitches per piece. That level of craft makes it impossible for copycats to replicate cheaply. Originality became a business strategy, not just an artistic principle.

The Business Model

What They Did Differently

Decision	What Most D2C Brands Do	What MyDesignation Did
Distribution	Rely heavily on Amazon, Flipkart, Myntra for volume	90% of revenue from own website. Built direct customer relationships first.
Product Releases	Hundreds of new styles weekly, chasing trends	Curated drop model. Limited designs, high craft, built on creative concepts.
Customer Acquisition	Heavy spending on Instagram ads, influencer campaigns	Organic community building. 6.2 lakh followers without ad spend.
Design Philosophy	Copy trending designs from Western brands	Original designs rooted in Kerala culture and folklore. 90% designs are unique.
Fundraising	Raise early, burn cash for growth, worry about profits later	Bootstrapped and profitable for 5 years before raising a single rupee.

The result: sub-5% return rates (industry average is 25-40%), 30-35% monthly repeat purchases, and a 4.8-star Google rating across 7,100+ reviews. These are the metrics that attracted institutional investors.

The Funding Timeline

Round	Amount	Lead Investor	Use of Funds
Seed (Feb 2025)	\$1.25M (Rs 10.7 Cr)	Multiply Ventures	Hiring, tech, offline expansion, new geographies
Series A (Feb 2026)	Rs 40 Cr (~\$4.4M)	RPSG Capital Ventures	8 new stores, senior leadership, new product categories

Veltis Capital doubled their equity stake in the Series A. When existing investors increase their position, it signals strong internal conviction about the company trajectory.

RPSG Capital Ventures is the same fund behind The Souled Store, mCaffeine, Perfora, Supertails, and Nutrabay. They manage a combined corpus of Rs 750 crore across 3 funds. Their investment thesis centres on consumer brands with genuine community moats.

What Attracted the Investors

Understanding why investors backed MyDesignation is where the real learning lives. Here are the six factors that turned a T-shirt brand from Kerala into a venture-backed company.

1. Cultural Storytelling as a Moat

In a market of generic fast fashion, MyDesignation rooted every collection in cultural narratives: Kathakali, Theyyam, Malayalam language, and local landmarks. This is hard to replicate. A well-funded competitor can copy a design, but they cannot copy a community that identifies with the culture behind it.

2. Disciplined, Profitable Growth

100% year-on-year revenue growth while remaining profitable. In the D2C world, where most brands burn cash to acquire customers, profitability from day one told investors these founders understood unit economics. They were raising from a position of strength, not desperation.

3. Exceptional Customer Loyalty

Return rates below 5%. Monthly repeat purchases at 30-35%. 4.8-star Google rating from 7,100+ reviews. 6.2 lakh Instagram followers built organically. These numbers together paint a picture of a brand people genuinely love, not one they bought from once because of a discount code.

4. The Founder Dynamic

Sambit Dash of RPSG Capital specifically highlighted the founders' combination of creativity, passion, and disciplined execution. Gopika's design sensibility paired with Swaroop's business and marketing acumen created a complementary team. Their refusal to take shortcuts (no trend-copying, no dependency on third-party platforms for growth) signaled long-term thinking.

5. Tier 2 City Disruption

MyDesignation is among the first fashion startups from a Tier 2 city to disrupt the national market. For investors, this represented a new archetype: a brand with deep regional roots that could scale nationally. The fact that they proved this from Thiruvananthapuram, without the typical Bangalore or Mumbai startup ecosystem, made the story more compelling.

6. Originality as Business Strategy

Gopika has said that originality is non-negotiable. Their curated drop model, where they release limited carefully-designed pieces rather than flooding the market, protects creative integrity and builds anticipation. Investors saw this as a sustainable approach to premium brand building at accessible prices.

8 Lessons for Aspirational Founders

What makes these lessons valuable is that the business idea itself, selling printed T-shirts and apparel, is not novel. The execution and philosophy are what set it apart.

Lesson 1: You do not need a revolutionary idea. You need a revolutionary approach.

Selling apparel online is one of the most common business ideas in India. MyDesignation did it differently by infusing deep cultural identity into a commoditised product. A simple business becomes extraordinary when paired with genuine differentiation that competitors cannot copy.

Lesson 2: Build a community before you build a company.

Early growth came from genuine connection with their audience, not paid ads. Their designs spoke to cultural pride and identity. When customers feel like they belong to something, they do your marketing for you. This organic community building drove 100% year-on-year growth without burning cash.

Lesson 3: Profitability is not the enemy of growth.

By keeping 90% of revenue on their own website and following a curated drop model instead of mass production, they maintained healthy margins and minimised inventory risk. Profitability from early on gave them negotiating power with investors and meant they raised capital on their terms.

Lesson 4: Own your customer relationship.

Most D2C brands hand over their customer data and margins to third-party platforms for the convenience of traffic. MyDesignation chose to build their own website and stores as the primary channel, keeping 90% of revenue direct. This gave them customer data, full control over brand experience, and independence from platform algorithms and commissions.

Lesson 5: Your origin story is an asset, not a disadvantage.

Coming from Thiruvananthapuram was not a limitation. It became central to the brand narrative. Investors were drawn to the authenticity of a brand proudly rooted in its geography. If you are building from a Tier 2 or Tier 3 city, lean into it. It is a differentiator.

Lesson 6: Validate with real customers before scaling.

300 T-shirts at the Olam flea market. Sold out in 3 hours. 800 pre-orders on the spot. That was the proof of concept. They did not build a massive operation on assumptions. They tested the market with minimal investment and let customer response guide every next step.

Lesson 7: Creative integrity is a business strategy.

By refusing to copy trends, MyDesignation ensured their products could not be easily commoditised. This gave them pricing power, customer loyalty, and a defensible brand identity. Staying true to your creative vision, even when it is harder, often pays off in the long run.

Lesson 8: Time your fundraise from a position of strength.

MyDesignation raised its seed round only after proving profitability and strong growth over multiple years. By the time they went to investors, they had a compelling data story: 100% YoY growth, sub-5% return rates, high repeat rates, and nearly 1 million customers. Raising too early, before the metrics are in place, leads to unfavourable terms and unnecessary dilution.

The Takeaway

MyDesignation proves three things that matter for anyone building from Tier 2/3 India.

First, the next wave of great Indian brands is not coming from Mumbai or Bangalore. It is coming from the cities nobody is watching. Thiruvananthapuram produced a Rs 100 crore fashion brand. Your city can produce the next one.

Second, community is the most underrated moat in business. When your customers share your content, defend your brand in comment sections, and come back to buy 30-35% of the time every month, you have something no amount of ad spend can replicate.

Third, discipline beats speed. Five years of profitable bootstrapping gave MyDesignation more leverage than most startups get from five rounds of funding.

This case study was researched and compiled by Satya Vyas.

Follow @iamsatyavyas on Instagram for more Tier 2 India business stories.

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Sources: Kerala Technology News, Entrackr, India Retailing, StartupNews.fyi, StartupTalky, DealStreetAsia, Tracxn, Crunchbase